least six months. It answers to a certain restlessness within party ranks on account of non-performance. At least three cabinet ministers are also facing police inquiry in financial scams. The party also wanted wider regional and caste representation, as well as ensuring the rewarding of turncoats—former Congress state chief Arjun Modhwadi was one of the top inductees.

THE YOUNG FACE

"Anti-incumbency is being felt rather acutely after 27 years of BJP rule," admits a party insider. "The youth are troubled by economic headwinds. But they've never seen Congress rule and don't know the difference the BJP has made. They blame us for all problems. Patel is non-controversial but isn't seen as particularly dynamic." But it was prudent to signal continuity so as not to spook industry.

Takeaways

- **The suave Sanghavi, 40, is from a Jain diamond trading family, and an arch party man**
- **His surprise elevation as deputy CM is meant to take the edge off youth unrest**

That's where Sanghavi comes in—suave, charming, ambitious, and not the least, a counter to AAP's Gopal Italia, whose exhortations are fuelling Gujarat's restless youth. With the backing of leading Jain businessmen, and a savoir faire that belies his Grade 9 education, Sanghavi has what the BJP needs the most—organic popularity, while being a faithful knight close to Narendra Modi, Amit Shah and C.R. Paatil, and time spent in the party crusades.

Among portfolios, home, usually retained by the CM, has gone to Sanghavi. He also retains sports, a key onus as Gujarat gets set to host the Commonwealth Games in 2030, with its eyes on Olympics 2036. ■

▶ CHHATTISGARH / MAHARASHTRA

HUGE CRACKS IN THE RED EDIFICE

Two big Maoist rebels lay down arms—a crafty surrender policy helps silence guns peacefully

By **Rahul Noronha**

IT WAS LIKE A DIWALI BONUS: TWO TOP MAOISTS laying down arms, each with a huge trail of cadre and arms. It happened separately, in Maharashtra and Chhattisgarh, but as part of a single wave—like parts of a weakened mountain crumbling. Those who have come in from the bush call it not a surrender but a continuation of their work for the oppressed, minus arms. An indulgent State is welcoming it and playing along—in Chhattisgarh, it even christened it 'Puna Margem' (A New Life) to mark it out as a rehabilitation.

Call it what you will, it's the one of the biggest subsidence of insurgency in these parts. On October 14, in Maharashtra's Gadchiroli, it was politburo and central committee (CC) member M. Venugopal Rao alias Bhupathi or Sonu who turned himself in; 60 cadres followed, with a 54-weapon cache. A day later, a formal ceremony happened before CM Devendra Fadnavis. Then, on October 17, 210 cadres led by CC member Satish alias Rupesh surrendered before Chhattisgarh CM Vishnu Deo Sai at Jagdalpur.

The cause of this turn to pacifism? Not hard to divine. The insurgency has been taking heavy hits in the security blitzkrieg ongoing since December 2023, with Maoist casualties pegged at 470-plus. Even a top gun like general secretary Nambala Keshava Rao alias Basavaraju lay slain in Abujhmad this May.

A few months ago, Sonu, who headed the Maoist education wing



PTI

NEW DAWN Senior Maoist leader Bhupathi (second from right) surrenders before Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis in Gadchiroli, Oct. 15